AI Nexus
HONEST AI RESEARCH

AI Tools Comparison Cheat Sheet

October 2026 edition · prices checked Oct 2026

Entry prices, free plans and billing models for the AI tools we covered this month, plus what changed in 2026. These are list prices as reported by vendors and pricing guides. Plans move often, so confirm on each vendor's page before you buy.

Pricing at a glance

TOOL	BEST FOR	FREE PLAN	ENTRY PAID PLAN · HOW YOU'RE BILLED
RESEARCH & ASSISTANTS			
Perplexity	Cited research	Yes, limited	Pro $20/mo ($200/yr); Max $200/mo; Education $10/mo
Claude	Writing, reasoning, coding agent	Yes, limited	Pro $20/mo; Max $100 or $200/mo. One shared usage pool
Notion AI	AI inside docs	Limited trial	Full AI is in Business, $20/seat/mo annual. The $8–10 add-on is retired
CODING & BUILDING			
Cursor	AI code editor	Hobby, free	Pro $20; Pro+ $60; Ultra $200; Teams $40/user. A credit pool plus overages
GitHub Copilot	In-IDE assistance	Limited	Pro $10/mo. Chat and agent use draws on AI Credits (since Jun 1, 2026); completions stay unlimited
Claude Code	Terminal coding agent	Needs a paid plan	Included with Claude Pro ($20) and Max ($100–200)
Replit	Build in the browser	Yes	Core $20–25/mo. Credits cover AI, compute and deploys
Lovable	Prompt-to-app, non-developers	30 credits/mo cap	Pro $25/mo ($21 annual); Business $50. Complexity-weighted credits
AUTOMATION & AGENTS			
Zapier	Biggest app library	100 tasks, two-step Zaps	Professional $19.99/mo annual (750 tasks). Billed per task
Make	Visual branching workflows	1,000 credits/mo	Core about $9/mo annual (10,000 credits); sources say $9–12. Billed per credit
n8n	Deep AI-agent features	Free if self-hosted	Cloud Starter €20/mo annual (2,500 executions). Billed per workflow run
Lindy, Relevance AI, Gumloop	Goal-driven agents	Varies	Entry plans reported at about $19–50/mo; **pricing was reworked in 2026**
VOICE			
ElevenLabs	Default for most creators	Yes	Starter $5–6; Creator $22; Pro $99 per month. Credits
Cartesia	Real-time voice agents	Yes	Pro $5/mo
Murf AI	Video & e-learning voiceover	Limited	Creator $19/mo annual ($29 monthly)
WellSaid Labs	Enterprise English narration	Check site	About $55/user/mo (Creative)
AI BROWSERS			
Perplexity Comet	Agentic browsing	Free core	Mac, Windows, Android
Dia (Atlassian)	AI-first browser	Yes	Pro $20/mo. Mac first; a Windows build was reported on Oct 7, 2026

What changed · API prices · Rules

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What changed in 2026 (and many roundups still miss)

ChatGPT Atlas	Discontinued. OpenAI set Aug 9, 2026 as the shutdown date. Its features moved to the ChatGPT desktop app, a Chrome extension and a cloud browser
Cursor	Acquired by SpaceX in a $60B all-stock deal that closed Aug 14, 2026. Billing is now a credit pool, not "500 fast requests"
Play.ht	Shut down Dec 31, 2025 after Meta hired the PlayAI team. Accounts and cloned voices were deleted
Notion AI	Standalone $8–10 add-on retired. Full AI now comes with the $20/seat Business plan
GitHub Copilot	Still $10/mo, but chat and agent use is metered in monthly AI Credits since Jun 1, 2026
Claude Sonnet 5 API	The planned Sept 1 increase to $3/$15 was cancelled. $2/$10 per million tokens stays
Make	"Operations" are now "credits"
Lovable	Priced in credits rather than messages: Pro $25, Business $50

LLM API pricing per million tokens (input / output)

MODEL	PROVIDER	INPUT	OUTPUT	NOTE
GPT-5.5	OpenAI	$5.00	$30.00	Surcharge >270K
GPT-5.4	OpenAI	$2.50	$15.00	Surcharge >270K
GPT-5.4 mini	OpenAI	$0.75	$4.50	
Claude Opus 4.8	Anthropic	$5.00	$25.00	1M, flat rate
Claude Sonnet 5	Anthropic	$2.00	$10.00	1M, flat rate
Claude Haiku 4.5	Anthropic	$1.00	$5.00	200K
Gemini 3.1 Pro Preview	Google	$2.00–4.00	$12.00–18.00	Tiered by context
Gemini 3.5 Flash	Google	$1.50	$9.00	
Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite	Google	$0.10	$0.40	Free tier

Three rules before you buy

1

Ask how it decides what to do next

"It follows the workflow I configure" is automation. "An LLM reasons about the next step" is an agent. Predictable inputs and costly errors point to automation; variable inputs and recoverable errors point to an agent.

2

Compare the billing unit, not the headline price

The same 4-step workflow run 2,000 times a month costs about $69–100+ on Zapier (per task), about $9 on Make (per credit) and about $5 on self-hosted n8n (per run).

3

A citation is a lead, not proof

In a March 2025 Columbia Tow Center test, even the best AI search tool, Perplexity, gave the wrong source 37% of the time. Ask for the primary source, click it, check the date, confirm there.